



a AI Highlight ▾

How I Know Whether It Actually Helped

My outcome measure is boring. Does it still hit as hard later? By restimulation I mean what happens when I remember the event again: does the same charge come back into my body and mind?

While working on this article I was still affected by something that happened with my housemate the day before. I was washing all her moldy clothes for her, one of the dresses got discolored, and she yelled at me. I was still stewing over how she treated me.

So I did a quick bit of self-Brainspotting. I moved my finger and eyes slowly around while thinking about the event. Farther to either side, as I moved into more peripheral vision, I noticed blissful tingles. There is a popular simple claim that peripheral vision activates the parasympathetic nervous system. I do not take my experience as proof of that; the research is more complicated.

Subjectively I could move my gaze from a position where I felt settled and noticed blissful tingles to a position where I felt distressed, moment by moment, and kind of move the bliss into the distress while I thought about the event. Afterward it felt as if the event held less negative energy, or less blocking energy, in my mind. That only tells me what happened right then.

The important version of me is the one an hour later, not the one enjoying the final minute of the exercise. If I am still stewing just as hard, perhaps the effect was temporary and I should try again. If I can remember what happened and feel less restimulated, that is more durable. I don't expect one treatment to erase everything; one EMDR session is often not enough either.

A bigger intervention leaves a wake, and sometimes I only notice it the next day. What happened to sleep? Am I more irritable, more dissociated, in more pain? Do I feel compelled to keep processing? How am I treating people? A calm final ten minutes does not prove the dose was right.

Research matters to me. I just don't use the size of a literature as a ranking algorithm for my nervous system. A shaking, qigong, breathwork, or somatic community may say that a practice releases decades of trauma, awakens kundalini, clears stored emotion, or rapidly heals the whole nervous system. My result cannot prove all those explanations. I look at people whose patterns resemble mine, change one thing at a time when I can, and keep returning to the unglamorous question: am I actually doing better?